South Africa's large fuel market relies on substantial imports

21.0bn L

Estimated demand, 2025

8.9bn petrol and 12.1bn diesel

5.8bn L

Domestic production assumption

National planning baseline

16.7bn L

Gross import requirement

Broadly matches recorded imports

A substantial demand base

Road transport is the largest use. Mining, agriculture, manufacturing and power also contribute.

Demand has eased from 21.9bn litres in 2023 to an estimated 21.0bn in 2025.

Durban connects imports to inland customers

Durban customs recorded 13.16bn litres of imports in 2025. The Durban–Lesedi route provides access to inland demand, subject to customer and logistics access.

South Africa has an established import market serving a large national fuel requirement.

Department national sales; SARS 2025 trade; analytical workbook v02. 2025 demand is estimated; 5.8bn L production is a planning assumption. Gross import need includes exports and assumes no stock change.

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Changes in demand, domestic supply and import routes could reduce flows through Durban

Driver	What changes for fuel demand and Durban flows
Sector activity	Mining, manufacturing and agriculture follow different growth paths, changing equipment and freight demand.
Eskom recovery	More reliable electricity reduces peaking and backup diesel at utilities, mines, factories and farms.
Road-to-rail	Freight transferred from trucks to rail reduces road diesel use; the net effect also depends on rail traction.
Vehicle efficiency	Lower fuel consumption per kilometre reduces demand for a given level of road activity.
Domestic production	Higher refinery output or restarts could displace imports. Lower output increases import dependence.
Competing gateways	Matola offers an alternative inland route. Assess Walvis Bay on delivered cost, reliability and access; diversion is unquantified.

A large national import market does not automatically translate into growth for Vopak.

Stats SA sector activity and freight; Eskom Integrated Report 2025 p141; Sasol and Glencore production disclosures; Galp and Petromoc infrastructure disclosures. Detailed evidence: South Africa story v37 pp7–11.

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How the national fuel market translates into Vopak's addressable volume

Sizing step	Basis for the calculation	Market measure
1 National demand	Petrol and diesel demand by end-use segment; apply sector, power, rail and efficiency drivers.	21.0bn L in 2025 Estimated demand
2 Import requirement	Demand − domestic production + exports + stock build (or − stock draw).	16.7bn L in 2025 Gross import need
3 Gateway allocation	Allocate to Durban, other SA ports and Matola; assess Walvis Bay. Compare delivered cost, reliability and access.	Durban-served pool Route shares to establish
4 Addressable flows	Identify customers and products Vopak can serve, given routes, contracts and terminal access.	Addressable volume Customer-level assessment
5 Achievable capture	Apply achievable customer capture; identify Lesedi onward volumes within the same Durban fuel flow.	2.63bn L illustration Includes 1.32bn L Lesedi
6 Capacity and investment	Compare incremental captured flow with usable tanks, stock turns, receipt and dispatch capacity.	Capacity shortfall Basis for investment

Size total demand, addressable flows and capture separately; count Durban–Lesedi fuel once.

Framework: analytical workbook v02 and market-sizing workbook. Gateway shares and customer access require validation. Walvis Bay is a route to assess; no diversion volume is assigned. Stock build increases import need; stock draw reduces it.

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Substantial imports sustain the market, while customer capture determines Vopak's expansion

16.6bn L

2030 national imports

Base-case imports across all gateways. Activity growth broadly offsets power, rail and efficiency reductions; domestic production stays at 5.8bn litres.

2.63bn L

Illustrative Durban capture

Assumes 20% of Durban's 2025 import pool. Includes 1.32bn litres onward through Lesedi within the same fuel flow.

Illustrative share; no explicit deduction for Matola or Walvis Bay diversion.

Expansion follows secured incremental flow

The illustrative flow fits the preliminary working-tank calculation.

Secure additional customer volumes, establish usable capacity, and identify the constraint that investment would solve.

Invest where secured additional volumes create a demonstrated capacity shortfall.

Analytical workbook v02 base scenario; market-sizing workbook and working-capacity assessment. Capture is illustrative; Lesedi is included within Durban flow. Contracted share, product balance and usable capacity remain to be established.

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